To Kill a Mockingbird: Key Text Quotations

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Key Quotations

The examiners' report notes that candidates do not have to use exact quotations and that "examples can be specific references to specific episodes in the novel studied or paraphrased quotations". Quotations are also a helpful way to demonstrate a thorough knowledge of events and moments in the text.

Below, you'll find definitions and analyses of some important quotes, grouped according to the following themes:

- Difference
- Inside and outside
- Childhood and adulthood
- Justice and injustice
- Education

Difference

Difference is a central theme in To Kill a Mockingbird. Throughout the novel, Lee explores a variety of ways in which people who are perceived as different are **marginalised**, including due to their race, gender and class.

Paired quotation

> **"As you grow older, you'll see white men cheat black men every day of your life, but let me tell you something and don't you forget it—whenever a white man does that to a black man, no matter who he is, how rich he is, or how fine a family he comes from, that white man is trash"** – Atticus, Chapter 23

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

Meaning and context

- The first quote is spoken by Atticus Finch following his defence of Tom Robinson, expressing his frustration with the prevailing racism
- The second quote is spoken by Scout after the trial, setting her apart from most others in her community who see people as segregated

Analysis

- In the first quote, Atticus emphasises that good morals are worth more than money:
  - The fact he likens racist people to trash links to Lee's presentation of Bob Ewell as living at the dump
- The second quote contrasts with the prevalent attitudes in Maycomb county by suggesting that all people are in fact equal

Help me understand

Paired quotation

> **"He ain't company, Cal, he's just a Cunningham"** – Scout, Chapter 3

> **"Hush your mouth! Don't matter who they are, anybody sets foot in this house's yo' comp'ny, and don't you let me catch you remarkin' on their ways like you was so high and mighty!"** – Calpurnia, Chapter 3

Meaning and context

- The first quote is spoken by Scout to Calpurnia after Jem has invited Walter Cunningham over to the Finch household for food
- The second quote is Calpurnia's response to Scout

Analysis

- In these quotes, Calpurnia scolds Scout and reminds her about how she should treat others
- Calpurnia suggests that Scout should be ashamed for treating Walter Cunningham differently:
  - She suggests that Scout should treat everyone with dignity and without prejudice

Inside and outside

The theme of the inside and the outside enables Lee to explore division and the danger of applying **binary thought** to complexities of community and human nature. Through the

intolerant society. The binary nature of inside and outside may also allude to the dangers of viewing the world through a series of simplistic opposites such as black people and white people, same and other, male and female.

Paired quotation

> **"Inside the house lived a malevolent phantom. People said he existed, but Jem and I had never seen him"** – Scout, Chapter 1

> **"If there's just one kind of folks, why can't they get along with each other? …I think I'm beginning to understand why Boo Radley's stayed shut up in the house all this time. It's because he wants to stay inside"** – Jem, Chapter 23

Meaning and context

- The first quote occurs at the start of the novel, in Chapter 1, setting the tone for the mystery surrounding Boo Radley and **foreshadowing** his importance in the novel:
  - Narrated by Jean Louise "Scout" Finch, it reveals a childlike fascination with a person who has become a monster in her mind due to the rumours she has heard
- The second quote is spoken by Jem after Tom Robinson has been wrongfully convicted of the rape of Mayella Ewell:
  - In contrast to the Finch siblings' perception of Boo at the start of the novel, this marks a dramatic change:
    - Both Jem and Scout understand that the real source of fear is the discrimination around them, not a harmless, reclusive man

Analysis

- In the first quote, the **metaphor** "a **malevolent** phantom" **dehumanises** Boo, **epitomising** how ignorance and hearsay can build unfounded fear and prejudice
- By describing Boo as "malevolent", it reveals that Scout has already decided that Boo is bad, even though she has "never seen him":
  - Here, Lee seems to be suggesting that people make value judgements about others without knowing or understanding them
- The use of the word "phantom" is also revealing:
  - A phantom is something that can cause dread and fear, but it also means something "without substance":
    - By choosing this term, Lee highlights both the fear surrounding the mysterious Boo, but also the

because of rumours she has heard

- The second quote makes it clear that Jem has matured and understood the intolerance of Maycomb society and why some may prefer to stay outside it:
  - In Jem's realisation that people are "all alike" Lee seems to be criticising the absurdity of treating people differently on the basis of their ethnicity, gender, class or age

Examiner Tips and Tricks

It is best to use short quotes in your answers, making sure they form part of your argument, rather than including a long quote just to show that you have learnt it.

Childhood and adulthood

By using a child narrator, Harper Lee is able to present the events of the story from a young person's viewpoint, highlighting the impact of adults' prejudices on children and revealing the ridiculousness of racism and other forms of discrimination.

> **"I hope and pray I can get Jem and Scout through it without bitterness, and most of all, without catching Maycomb's usual disease"** – Atticus, Chapter 9

Meaning and context

- This quote is from Atticus during a conversation with his brother, Jack Finch, about bringing up Jem and Scout

Analysis

- It is clear that Atticus understands how perceptive children are, and the importance of adults being honest with them:
  - He realises the impact adults can have on children and is determined to bring them up with good values

In referring to intolerance as "Maycomb's usual disease" Lee presents prejudice as something that spreads and is an **ill of society**

Justice and injustice

novel also explores how injustice **permeates** wider society, evidenced here in the classroom and casual conversation.

> **"We are a democracy"** – Miss Gates, Chapter 26

> **"I heard her [Miss Gates] say it's time somebody taught 'em a lesson, they were gettin' way above themselves, an' the next thing they think they can do is marry us"** – Scout, Chapter 26

> **"In our courts, when it's a white man's word against a black man's, the white man always wins. They're ugly, but those are the facts of life"** – Atticus, Chapter 23

Meaning and context

- The first quote is an exchange between Scout and Miss Gates in the class at school, after the trial of Tom Robinson
- In the second quote, Scout talks about what she heard Miss Gates say about African-American people
- In the third quote, Atticus talks about the injustice of the Tom Robinson case as a **microcosm** of racial prejudice on a larger scale

Analysis

- In class, Miss Gates **espouses** the idea of equality for all, implying that it is value upheld in American society
- The outward views of Miss Gates contrast with her true beliefs, as evidenced when Scout recalls what she heard her teacher say privately:
  - This serves to highlight societal **hypocrisy**; here Lee criticises the idea of **segregation**, enforced by the **Jim Crow laws**, suggesting that it is un-American:
    - Miss Gates's implication that "it's time somebody taught 'em a lesson" hints at violence as a means of control

- The third quote highlights the injustice in the courts and the failure of the legal system to provide a fair trial to all, regardless of race:
  - The fact that the jury convict Tom without looking him in the eye supports this argument:
    - Through this, Lee exposes the unfairness of Jim Crow Laws and draws attention to the plight of African American people, perhaps to increase support for the **Civil Rights Movement**

Education

Harper Lee presents education as a way of making society better, but not through formal schooling. Scout and Jem's intelligence and thoughtfulness are shown to be a result of what they have learned from Atticus, not from their teachers at school. From this point of view, Lee offers a critique of formal education in focusing on following a system rather than teaching good values, morality and fairness.

> **"I'm just trying to tell you the new way they're teachin' the first grade, stubborn. It's the Dewey Decimal System... Miss Caroline caught me writing and told me to tell my father to stop teaching me."** – Scout, Chapter 2

Meaning and context

- In this quote, Scout tells Atticus how she has been told off at school for knowing how to read, as her learning does not comply with the Dewey Decimal System

Analysis

- This demonstrates that education and society often **stymy** individuality:
  - The fact that students "won't learn to write until ... the third grade" further suggests that this system undermines progress and individuality
  - Teachers often symbolise a society's values
  - In this instance, the classroom could be argued to represent society in Maycomb, Alabama where conformity wins over individuality and intolerance wins over tolerance

Sources:

Lee, H. (2010). To Kill a Mockingbird. Arrow Books.

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